

COW FACE

Gomukhasana

This seated pose involves unique actions of your shoulder joints. This can be helpful in stretching out tight shoulders, particularly if you work at a desk and spend a lot of time typing—but you should avoid this pose if you have a rotator cuff injury. Switch arms and notice if you feel a difference between each side.

THE BIG PICTURE

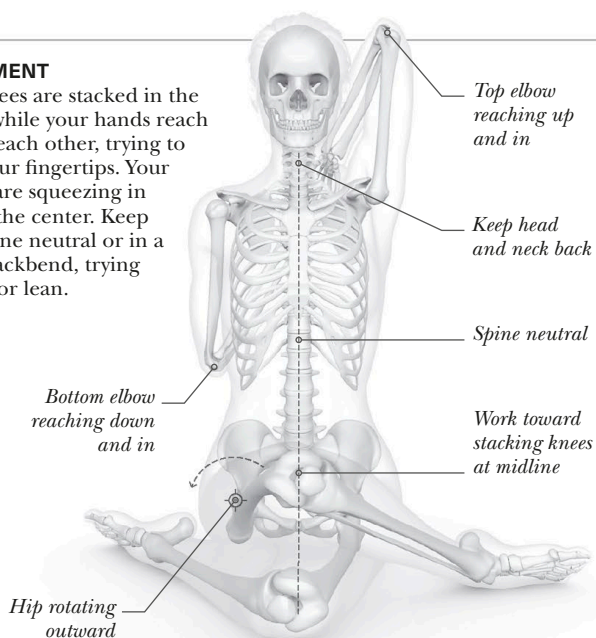
In this seated pose, you particularly stretch around your shoulders and the outside of your hips and buttocks. You are also engaging key postural muscles to counteract slouching or rounding forward.

KEY

- Joints
- Muscles
- Engaging
- Engaging while stretching
- Stretching

ALIGNMENT

Your knees are stacked in the center while your hands reach toward each other, trying to clasp your fingertips. Your elbows are squeezing in toward the center. Keep your spine neutral or in a slight backbend, trying to twist or lean.



Top arm

Your shoulder flexors—**anterior deltoid** and **pectoralis major**—flex your shoulder. Your **middle deltoid** and **supraspinatus** stabilize and abduct it, and your **infraspinatus**, **teres minor**, and **posterior deltoid** engage to externally rotate. Your elbow flexors engage and **triceps brachii** stretches.

Torso

Your **spinal extensors** and **transversus abdominis** engage to slightly extend and stabilize your spine, while your **rectus abdominis** stretches. Your **rhomboids** engage to retract your **scapulae**.

Reach elbows in as much as possible

Grip strap while holding pose



VARIATION

If you cannot reach your hands together, use a strap or towel to extend your reach. If you hold for approximately 10 breaths, you may find you can walk your fingers closer toward each other.

